Matthew 23:27-28 — Summary

Date: 2026-07-01

Baseline Translation: ESV (English Standard Version)

Original Language: Greek (NA28/Nestle 1904)

Analyst: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

Passage Context: Seven Woes pericope, the culminating woe (vv27-28) — Jesus introduces the "whited sepulchre" image: a tomb painted beautiful on the outside but full of dead men's bones and uncleanness within. v28 makes the metaphor explicit: EVEN SO the Pharisees appear righteous to men but are full of hypocrisy and iniquity. The two verses form a paired image-and-application structure that completes the Seven Woes.

Diff Analysis: What Got Lost?

What the Standard Translation Loses

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
1	"whited" (v27)	The Greek (kekoniaμenoi) means whitewashed — plastered over with a false surface. The LSJ shows it used metaphorically for painting or disguising a face, and cites THIS VERSE.	"Whited" sounds like simply "made white." The Greek carries the force of COVERING OVER — plastering a false surface. The beauty is APPLIED, not native. Someone did this to the sepulchre.
2	"sepulchres" (v27)	The Greek (taphoi) means graves — places of interment. The LSJ shows "in sepulchres" = "dead and	ESV's "sepulchres" is accurate but loses the force: a sepulchre is a PLACE OF DEATH. The dead are IN it. Jesus says the

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
		buried." The word is inseparable from DEATH.	Pharisees are like graves — containers of the deceased.
3	"beautiful" (v27)	The Greek (oraioi) primarily means "seasonable, timely, flourishing" — imagery of FRUIT and HARVEST. The LSJ cites THIS VERSE for this sense.	"Beautiful" means pretty. The Greek means FLOURISHING — ripe, in its prime. The sepulchre appears to be thriving, full of life — when it is full of death. The irony: the tomb looks ALIVE.
4	"appear" (v27, v28)	The Greek (fainw) means to shine forth, to bring to light, to make known. Categories: action>perception AND nature>fire_light.	"Appear" can be passive. The Greek carries the force of EMITTING LIGHT — the sepulchre SHINES beauty. The Pharisees SHINE righteousness. The beauty is a PERFORMANCE.
5	"uncleanness" (v27)	The Greek (akathapsia) means impurity — physically (foulness of a wound) AND morally (depravity). Secondary category: ritual>purity_rite — the OPPOSITE of purification.	"Uncleanness" sounds like dirtiness. The Greek carries ceremonial force — it's the opposite of the purification rite. The sepulchre is DEFILED in the ritual sense.
6	"indeed...but" (v27, v28)	The Greek men...de is a known classical concessive pair — men affirms/ concedes, de contrasts. The structure concedes the surface before delivering the interior verdict.	The ESV translates as "which...but" — losing the concessive force. Jesus says: YES, outwardly they DO appear beautiful (concession granted) — BUT inwardly they are full of death.

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7	"Even so" (v28)	The Greek (οὕτως) means "in this way" — referring directly back to v27's whited sepulchre. The Pharisees ARE the sepulchres.	ESV's "Even so" is adequate but loses the tie. The Greek says: IN THIS WAY — the way of the whited sepulchre. v28 is the explicit statement of v27's metaphor.
8	"righteous" (v28)	The Greek (dikaios) means "observant of duty to gods AND men." The LSJ shows it as fulfilling obligations to BOTH gods and humans. Its opposite is "unrighteous."	"Righteous" is a general moral term. The Greek is specific: fulfilling duty to gods AND men. The Pharisees appear righteous TO MEN — but God is not in the audience.
9	"unto men" (v28)	The Greek (anthropois) means humans — mankind. The Pharisees appear righteous TO MEN. Not to God.	The audience of the performance is humanity, not divinity. God sees the inside. The Pharisees perform for men, and God is not fooled.
10	"hypocrisy" (v28)	The Greek (hypokrisis) means "acting under a feigned part" — stage-playing. The LSJ cites THIS VERSE: "playing a part, hypocrisy, outward show."	"Hypocrisy" is general insincerity. The Greek means STAGE-PLAYING — performing a role. It connects to v27's "hypocrites" (actors) and "appear" (shining). The righteousness is a ROLE.
11	"iniquity" (v28)	The Greek (anomias) means "lawlessness, the negation of law" — the opposite of nomos (law). Not wickedness within a framework but the	"Iniquity" means wickedness. The Greek means WITHOUT LAW — the moral framework has been removed. The Pharisees don't just break the law; they live outside it.

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
		ABSENCE of the framework.	
12	Escalation from v25 to v27	v25: cup/platter full of robbery (theft). v27: sepulchre full of dead men's bones (DEATH). The image escalates from crime to mortality.	Each woe sharpens the indictment. The Pharisees go from thieves to corpse-bearers. Their inside doesn't just contain crime; it contains the DEAD.
13	"full" shift from v27 to v28	v27 uses gemusin ("to swell out, be full from" — ORIGIN). v28 uses mesotw ("replete, full of" — SATURATION). Different words for "full."	v27: the sepulchre is full FROM death (death is the source). v28: the Pharisees are SATURATED with hypocrisy (hypocrisy fills every part). The shift from origin to saturation deepens the indictment.

Concepts Flattened

- **Whitewashing as covering over**: "Whited" means plastered with a false surface — the beauty is APPLIED, not native. The sepulchre didn't become white on its own; someone painted it. The hypocrisy is in the act of whitewashing.
- **Flourishing vs. pretty**: "Beautiful" means seasonable, timely, flourishing — the imagery of harvest. The sepulchre appears to be thriving when it is full of death. The beauty is the beauty of a harvest — and the harvest is corpses.
- **Sepulchre as place of death**: A sepulchre is a grave — a container of the deceased. The Pharisees are like graves: they carry the dead within themselves.
- **Appearing as shining**: "Appear" means to emit light, to shine forth. The Pharisees don't just passively look righteous; they actively SHINE righteousness. The beauty is a performance.
- **Righteous as dual obligation**: "Righteous" means observant of duty to gods AND men. The Pharisees perform for humans only; God sees through the performance.

- **Hypocrisy as stage-playing**: "Hypocrisy" means playing a role on the stage. The Pharisees are actors performing righteousness — the righteousness is a character they play, not a truth they live.
- **Iniquity as the negation of law**: "Iniquity" means lawlessness — the absence of the legal framework, not just a violation within it. The Pharisees live outside the law entirely.
- **The men...de concessive pair**: "Indeed...but" — Jesus concedes the surface beauty/righteousness before delivering the interior verdict. The structure is a rhetorical takedown: I see your surface, I concede your surface, and now I show you your interior.

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Expanded Translation (4K)

The recovered "director's cut" — original language nuances restored in readable English. Parenthetical notes explain the nuance recovered.

27 Woe (an exclamation of pain and anger — not just "alas" but the cry of grief itself) unto you, scribes (and "scribes" means secretaries, registrars, subordinate officials — a word sometimes used as a term of contempt) and Pharisees (and "Pharisees" means separatists — those who have made themselves exclusively religious, a sect apart), hypocrites (and "hypocrites" literally means stage-players — actors under an assumed character, performing a role rather than living a truth)! For ye are like (and "like" means to resemble — to be put in the same class with) whited (and "whited" means whitewashed — plastered over with lime, daubed with a false surface; the classical lexicon shows it used metaphorically for painting or disguising a face, and cites THIS VERSE for that metaphorical sense) sepulchres (and "sepulchres" means graves — places of interment, tombs; the classical lexicon shows that "in sepulchres" means "dead and buried," and that a "living sepulchre" means a living skeleton — the word is inseparable from DEATH), which outwardly (and "outwardly" means from without — from the outside, the external surface) indeed (and "indeed" is a particle of affirmation and concession — it acknowledges what follows as true, but sets up a contrast with what comes after "but") appear (and "appear" means to shine forth, to bring to light — not merely to "look" a certain way but to EMIT light, to display, to make known)

beautiful (and "beautiful" means seasonable, timely, flourishing — it belongs to the imagery of FRUIT and HARVEST, of things ripe and in their prime; the classical lexicon cites THIS VERSE for this sense), but inwardly (and "inwardly" means from within — from inside, the interior) they are full (and "full" means to swell out, to be full — the classical lexicon cites the construction "full from" for fullness BY ORIGIN) of dead (and "dead" means corpses — those who dwell in the nether world, the deceased) men's bones, and of all (and "all" means every kind, the whole) uncleanness (and "uncleanness" means impurity — physically, the foulness of a wound or sore, dirt and filth; but also morally, depravity and ceremonial impurity; the same word family used for the opposite of purification rites)!

28 Even so (and "even so" means "in this way" — referring directly back to the whited sepulchre of v27; the Pharisees ARE the sepulchres) ye also outwardly (and "outwardly" means from without — from the outside, the external surface, the same word used in v27) indeed (and "indeed" is the same concessive particle from v27 — affirming what follows as true while setting up the contrast) appear (and "appear" means to shine forth, to bring to light — the same word from v27; the Pharisees EMIT a false surface) righteous (and "righteous" means equitable, innocent, holy — observant of duty to gods and men; the classical lexicon shows it means fulfilling one's obligations to BOTH gods AND humans, and that its opposite is "unrighteous") unto men (and "unto men" means to humans — the audience of the Pharisees' performance is humanity, not divinity; they appear righteous TO MEN, not to God), but inwardly (and "inwardly" means from within — from inside, the interior, the same word from v27) ye are full (and "full" means replete — the classical lexicon shows it used metaphorically for being full of knowledge and understanding, full in the sense of saturation) of hypocrisy (and "hypocrisy" means playing a part on the stage — acting under a feigned character; the classical lexicon cites THIS VERSE for the metaphorical sense of "playing a part, hypocrisy, outward show") and iniquity (and "iniquity" means lawlessness — the negation of law itself; the classical lexicon shows it as the opposite of "nomos" (law), not merely wickedness but the ABSENCE of law, lawless conduct opposed to lawful conduct)!

Baseline Translation (ESV)

> *27* *Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye are like unto whited sepulchres, which outwardly appear beautiful, but inwardly are full of dead men's bones, and of all uncleanness.*
>
> *28* *Even so ye also outwardly appear righteous unto men, but inwardly ye are full of hypocrisy and iniquity.*

Individual Verse Analyses

Each verse has its own detailed analysis file with full Greek text, word-by-word analysis, grammatical observations, cultural context, and cross-references:

- Matthew 23:27 — The whited sepulchre image: the Pharisees are like whitewashed graves (sepulchres — places of death, inseparable from the deceased within), which outwardly (from without) indeed appear (shine forth, emit light) beautiful (seasonable, flourishing, ripe — the imagery of harvest, not prettiness), but inwardly (from within) are full of dead men's bones (corpses of the nether world) and all uncleanness (ceremonial impurity — the opposite of the purification rite)
- Matthew 23:28 — The explicit application: even so (in this way — the Pharisees ARE the sepulchres), ye also outwardly indeed appear (shine forth — same word as v27) righteous (observant of duty to gods AND men) unto men (to humans — not to God), but inwardly ye are full of (saturated with) hypocrisy (stage-playing — performing a role, acting under a feigned character) and iniquity (lawlessness — the negation of law itself, the absence of the legal framework)

Theological Insights Recovered

1. **The whited sepulchre as painted-over death**: The Greek for "whited" (kekoniaμenoi) means whitewashed — plastered over with a false surface. The LSJ shows it used metaphorically for disguising a face, and cites THIS VERSE. The sepulchre didn't become beautiful on its own; someone PAINTED it beautiful. The hypocrisy is in the ACT of whitewashing — the Pharisees have applied a false surface to themselves, just as someone plastered a false surface onto the tomb. The beauty is APPLIED, not native.

2. **"Beautiful" as flourishing — the irony of the thriving tomb**: The Greek oraioi primarily means "seasonable, timely, flourishing" — the imagery of FRUIT and HARVEST. The LSJ cites THIS VERSE for this figurative sense. The sepulchre doesn't just look pretty — it appears FLOURISHING, ripe, in its prime, full of life. The irony is devastating: the tomb appears alive when it is full of death. The Pharisees appear flourishing when they are full of corruption. The beauty is the beauty of a harvest — and the harvest is corpses.

3. **The sepulchre as container of the dead**: The Greek taphoi means grave — the place of interment. The LSJ shows "in sepulchres" = "dead and buried" and "living sepulchre" = "living skeleton." Jesus isn't saying the Pharisees are like empty buildings; he's saying they're like GRAVES — containers of the deceased. The dead are IN them. The Pharisees carry the dead within themselves. The image shifts the Pharisees from sinners (v25's cup full of robbery) to corpse-bearers (v27's sepulchre full of dead men's bones).

4. **"Righteous" as the dual obligation to gods and men**: The Greek dikaios means "observant of duty to gods and men" — the LSJ is explicit about the DUAL obligation. The Pharisees appear righteous TO MEN — but the word "righteous" encompasses duty to BOTH gods and humans. God is not in the audience. God sees the inside. The Pharisees fulfill their duty to humans while failing their duty to God, and the word "righteous" — which demands BOTH — exposes the failure. They can't be righteous to God while being full of hypocrisy.

5. **"Hypocrisy" as stage-playing — the performance IS the crime**: The Greek hypokrisis means "acting under a feigned part" — playing a role on the stage. The LSJ cites THIS VERSE: "playing a part, hypocrisy, outward show." This connects directly to v27's "hypocrites" (actors performing a character) and "appear" (shining forth). The hypocrisy IS the performance — the Pharisees are actors, and their righteousness is a role they play. The word carries the force of DECEPTION through performance, not mere insincerity but active impersonation.

6. **"Iniquity" as the negation of law**: The Greek anomias means "lawlessness, the negation of law" — the opposite of nomos (law). The word literally contains the negation: a- + nomos + -ia. The Pharisees' inside isn't just wicked; it's WITHOUT LAW. The moral framework has been removed entirely. They don't just break the law; they live outside it. This is the deepest indictment: not a violation within a legal framework, but the ABSENCE of the framework itself.

7. **The paired image-and-application structure**: v27 is the IMAGE (the whited sepulchre — beautiful outside, dead inside). v28 is the APPLICATION (EVEN SO — in this way — you appear righteous to men but are full of hypocrisy). The two verses form a rhetorical pair: v27 makes you SEE the image, v28 makes you HEAR the verdict. The parallel men...de structure (indeed...but) and repeated vocabulary (exhthen, eshthen, fainw) create a grammatical identification between the sepulchre and the Pharisees. The Pharisees ARE the sepulchres.

8. **The Luke 16:15 cross-reference — God knows your hearts**: Luke 16:15 says: "Ye are they which justify yourselves before men, but God knoweth your hearts: for that which is highly esteemed among men is abomination in the sight of God." The parallel is exact: the Pharisees appear righteous TO MEN, but God sees the inside. What men esteem (righteousness) is abomination to God. Matthew says the surface is false; Luke says God sees through it. Together they complete the theological point: the Pharisees perform for men, and God is not in the audience — God is behind the curtain.

9. **The escalation across the Seven Woes**: The progression of the pericope: v1 (general condemnation — "woe unto you"), v23 (tithe trifles, omit justice — failing in duty), v25 (cleanse the outside, full of robbery — surface vs. substance), v27-28 (whited sepulchres, full of death and hypocrisy — image and application). Each woe sharpens

the indictment: from general grief → to failing in duty → to surface purity concealing robbery → to painted beauty concealing death. The final woe is the most devastating: the Pharisees are TOMBS full of dead men's bones, and they KNOW they are — their righteousness is a performance, their inside is without law, and God sees all of it.

10. **The "full" shift from origin to saturation**: v27 uses gemusin ("to swell out, be full from" — ORIGIN) while v28 uses mesotw ("replete, full of" — SATURATION). The shift deepens the indictment: v27 says the sepulchre is full FROM death (death is the source of the fullness). v28 says the Pharisees are SATURATED with hypocrisy (hypocrisy fills every part). The fullness moves from having a source in death to being total saturation with hypocrisy. There is no corner of the Pharisees' interior that is not full of it.

Notes for Further Study

- **Hebrew/OT sources**: The whited sepulchre image may have roots in Hebrew/Aramaic sources. The Acts 23:3 cross-reference ("thou whited wall") suggests the whitewashing metaphor was part of Jesus's rhetorical toolkit. Hebrew analysis of the Acts passage could reveal whether the image originates there.
- **The "flourishing" sense of oraioi**: The LSJ entry for oraioi is rich and deserves deeper study — the extension from "seasonable/timely" to "beautiful" follows a semantic path through harvest-imagery that may illuminate other verses where the same word appears.
- **The men...de construction across the pericope**: The same concessive structure appears in v25 and v27-28. A comprehensive study of Jesus's use of this construction across Matthew 23 could reveal it as a deliberate rhetorical pattern for the outside/inside opposition.
- **The shift from gemusin to mesotw**: The two words for "full" in v27 and v28 deserve closer comparison. Are there other verse pairs where Jesus shifts between origin-fullness and saturation-fullness? The semantic difference may be a deliberate rhetorical escalation.

- **Retroactive v3 conversion**: Older passages (Matthew 5:3-12, 22:41-45, 23:1-7) should be converted to the granular per-verse format with Strong's numbers and LSJ lookups for consistency.

Analysis completed by: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

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Formats: Markdown (.md) • HTML (.html) • PDF (.pdf)